

SESSION TWO: THE ROAD BACK

The Qilvayas Symphony

An adventure for 4–6 characters of 3rd level — the journey to the capital, and the woman with the still waters

OVERVIEW

The morning after the vision, the party must return to the capital regardless of what they decide about the dream — their field exercise concludes with a formal report to the academy, and graduation is weeks away. The road home becomes a tour of the fractured empire at ground level: a checkpoint that answers to no one in particular, refugees from a war nobody declared, and a toll collected on forged authority. In the capital, an old archivist points them toward the only person who might explain what happened to them — and the session ends in a modest apartment with blue shutters, across a table from Vaelindra of the Still Waters.

Designed for a five-hour session, which comfortably fits all three road encounters — run them all, in any order. Suggested pacing budget: the morning after (45 minutes); the road encounters (50 minutes each, 150 total); arrival at the capital (20 minutes); the academy and the archivist (45 minutes); finding Vaelindra (40 minutes). The Vaelindra scene must end the session on her confirmation, not her explanation — hold the full conversation for Session Three's opening. If time runs short, trim the toll bridge to its reveal-and-fold beat rather than cutting it entirely; its thematic note is worth thirty seconds even in passing.

SCENE 1: THE MORNING AFTER

Open at the Gilded Ford's common room at dawn. Do not summarize — let the party have the conversation. Useful questions to let hang in the air: Do they tell anyone? (Their exercise supervisor expects a report; does the dream go in it?) Do they still graduate and found the company as planned? Does anyone try to rationalize it — shared meal, shared stress, the thing at Redwatch preying on their minds? A character proposing the rational explanation should be allowed to — and should privately notice it does not survive contact with the details: six people do not dream the same engraving-perfect view of a city most have never visited, down to the count of the towers.

Academy characters know (no check needed) that prophecy and omens are Church jurisdiction — and that reporting a shared apocalyptic vision through official channels means clergy, questions, and possibly a heresy inquiry into whether they invited it. That institutional chill is worth making explicit early: it explains why the road to answers will run through quiet referrals instead of official ones.

SCENE 2: THE ROAD — THREE ENCOUNTERS

The journey to the capital takes four days by the imperial road. These encounters are modular and reorderable. None is primarily a combat encounter; each is the fractured empire teaching the party what restoration is actually up against. Combat statistics are provided in case the party chooses steel — the empire will not stop them from learning things the hard way.

ENCOUNTER A: THE CHECKPOINT AT VARN'S CROSSING

The imperial road narrows at a stone bridge, and across it stands a barrier of sharpened stakes that is definitely not imperial engineering. Soldiers in half-familiar colors — imperial cut, but the wolf on their tabards has been re-stitched over with a black elk — wave wagons into a queue. A hand-painted board reads: ROAD LEVY. 5 SILVER THE HEAD. BY ORDER OF LORD OSTREV, PROTECTOR OF THE CROSSING.

Sergeant Petra Malich commands twelve Provincial Soldiers. Lord Ostrev is a minor border lord, nominally loyal to the throne, who has decided that “protecting” this stretch of imperial road entitles him to tax it — a legal fiction with no imperial authorization whatsoever. Malich knows it, hates it, and enforces it, because her men have not been paid in anything but Ostrev's scrip for a year.

The interesting choice: academy signets exempt students from provincial tolls on imperial roads — by law. Invoking that law is legally airtight and socially explosive: Malich's face hardens, the queue of farmers watches students in capital uniforms walk free of a toll the farmers must pay, and the party gets its first taste of what imperial privilege looks like from underneath. Paying quietly, arguing the law, negotiating for the whole queue, or making a scene are all valid — there is no clean answer, which is the point. A DC 14 Charisma (Persuasion) check gets Malich talking honestly if the party is respectful: about pay, about Ostrev, about the last imperial inspector who came through (“four years ago; he took notes and a bribe, in that order”). Fighting twelve soldiers is possible and foolish; Malich's orders are to collect, not to die, and she yields the crossing rather than lose men — then reports it, and the party has made an enemy of a lord.

ENCOUNTER B: THE PEOPLE FROM HALVENNE

You smell the woodsmoke before you see them: forty-odd people camped in the ditch-shadow of the imperial road, in the organized misery of people who

have done this before. Cookfires, bundles, a mule that has been asked for too much. An old woman sits on a milestone as though it were a throne, watching you approach with the unhurried attention of someone who has already seen everything she was afraid of.

Refugees from Halvenne, a market village in the Brekelands two weeks west, burned in a skirmish between the companies of the warlords Bettra Skarn and Ilmarch Voss — the Granary War, as the sourcebook's Atlas has it: not a war, nothing so organized; a dispute over a granary that became a fire that became forty homeless families. They are walking to the capital because the old woman, Semya, remembers her grandmother saying the throne feeds its own. Nobody has the heart to tell her how long ago that was.

What this encounter is for: charity with real texture (the party has money now; what does it buy, and what can't it?), information (Semya's people passed three other burned villages this season — the border situation is worse than capital dispatches admit), and one quiet seed, delivered unprompted if the party is kind. Semya says:

"You're young for whatever's riding you. I'll tell you what I told the priest at Halvenne, before it burned: the dogs have been howling at nothing since the spring. The wells taste of ash where no fire's been. My grandmother had a word for a season like this one. She called it an indrawn breath."

Semya knows nothing concrete — she is not a seer, just old and paying attention. That is precisely why she matters: the world itself has begun registering what the party saw in the vision. If the party helps her people (coin, escort for a day, a letter to Ondrei recommending Dravenna take them in — that last is the elegant solution, and he will), Semya blesses them in the old country way and the campaign gains forty grateful witnesses in whatever place they land. If the party does nothing, the Halvenne refugees reach Aenodira anyway and disappear into Farrowgate, the district along the Long Wall where the fractured empire's displaced accumulate — and the party may meet them there again, in worse circumstances, wondering if anyone could have helped.

DM texture (optional, unremarked): a few among the band keep the northern rite, and at dusk they hold a brief roadside Vigil — a ring of small stones, a shared candle, a plain Orlathine cadence the party has no reason to recognize. It is Harvestide, and they are keeping the season's dead the way the north does. If asked, Semya says only, "We lost people in the south, some years back. This is the week for it." She means the Vintage Night, six years gone this week, and will not say the name to strangers. Players need not connect it to anything; it is the same season tolling under a different roof.

ENCOUNTER C: THE TOLL THAT ISN'T

The last river crossing before the capital district is a fine old imperial bridge — and a new chain across it, and a table, and a man in very good clothes behind the table, flanked by four professionals whose knuckles say they were not hired for their handwriting. The man smiles like a document with a seal on it. "Bridge maintenance assessment," he says. "One Zhuven the wagon, two strands the walker. All proper. I have the writ."

A carter waiting behind them, not quite under his breath: "A wolf. He means a wolf." Nobody who handles coin for a

living calls it a Zhuven, and the correction is the first thing about this bridge that is genuinely true.

Odric Hale is a racketeer with excellent paperwork. His writ is real parchment with a real wax seal — of the Office of the Imperial Roads Commission, Eastern Circuit, an office abolished sixty years ago. He bought the dead seal from a dealer in such things and has been farming this bridge for a season. A DC 13 Intelligence (History or Investigation) check — or any Seal-house character who handles the writ, automatically — spots the anachronism instantly. But the sharper move is the one the Zhuvedian Laws actually provide, and a Seal-house character knows it cold: the seal proves nothing on its own. Book Three's test is the register — challenge him to produce the entry that matches the mark, and he cannot, because the office that kept the register has been dead for sixty years. This is a gift of a moment for a law-focused character: the first time their education simply wins, and it wins by procedure rather than by trivia. Plant it here; Session Five is built on the same rule.

Confronted, Odric calculates: he folds instantly before force or credible legal threat (DC 12 Intimidation or Persuasion once the writ is exposed — he is a businessman, not a soldier), offers a 20 gp "administrative apology," and decamps to try again elsewhere unless the party escorts him to capital authorities, which they can. His enforcers fight only if the party attacks first, and abandon him at half strength. Scaling, if it does come to blows: baseline (4 characters) is Odric plus 3 Bridge Enforcers. For 5 characters, add 1 enforcer. For 6, add 2, and Odric retreats behind the bridge-house door rather than folding on the first failed check — he has more to lose and better cover. The thematic note, worth a beat at the table: sixty years on, the empire's dead institutions still have power — as costumes. A broken seal still opens purses. Authority outlives the thing that granted it. File that thought; the campaign will rhyme with it.

SCENE 3: THE CAPITAL

You crest the pilgrim hill at the hour the light goes bronze, and there it is — the city from a thousand engravings, the city from your nightmare. It is vast beyond the drawings: ring on ring of walls in three colors of stone from three ages of empire, the river bent around it like a guard's arm, and above the haze of a hundred thousand cookfires, the two summits every schoolchild knows — the golden dome of the Great Temple of the Matron, and the white mass of the imperial palace, holding up the Lupine Throne. It is magnificent. And because you have seen it burning — seen these exact towers, this exact skyline, wrapped in fire that moved wrong — your first sight of the capital arrives with a shadow already on it. The bells begin the evening peal, and every one of you, without meaning to, counts the towers. The count matches the dream.

(DM note: the capital is Aenodira — use the name freely in read-aloud and dialogue from this point forward. See the sourcebook's Geography and Locations section for the ring structure and district layout referenced below.) Keep the arrival to broad, textural strokes ahead of full street-level detail: grandeur next to strain. Triumphal columns with scaffolding on them; a great aqueduct arch bricked up and rented out as housing in the Archwork; imperial banners bright and new over gates whose stonework is patched. The Emperor's restoration is visible — fresh paint, work crews, official proclamations of the coming Zhuvedian Laws posted

at crossroads and along the Long Course — and so is everything it is up against.

(DM-only atmosphere, for a party that lingers or returns at dawn: the court keeps no public mourning for the Empress — there is no body, no confirmed death, and an interregnum the throne would rather forget, so the anniversary of her disappearance passes officially unmarked. What a sharp-eyed party might notice, and never be told the meaning of, is that on one grey Harvestide dawn the Emperor walks the Long Course alone, his guards held at a distance, longer than his usual circuit, and the proclamation-criers do not cry that morning. It is the third year. He has entered no room of hers in any of them. None of this is offered to the players; it is the season keeping its own accounts.)

SCENE 4: THE ACADEMY AND THE ARCHIVIST

The Imperial Academy of the Lupine Throne, in Scholar's Row, is the one place in Aenodira that feels fully ordered: swept courts, ringing bells, first-years drilling. The party files its exercise report (Ondrei's letter of commendation, if earned, raises eyebrows approvingly), and unless they volunteer the vision, the report closes routinely. Their supervising instructor notes they seem tired, congratulates them, and reminds them commencement is in five weeks.

The path to Vaelindra runs through Archivist Dathenor Vell — hill dwarf, ancient by human reckoning, keeper of the academy's restricted stacks, and precisely the kind of institutional fixture who has outlasted four chancellors by knowing everything and volunteering nothing. Any party that starts researching shared visions, omens, or prophetic phenomena in the library lands in his domain within the hour; alternatively, any trusted instructor, asked discreetly, sends them to him. Vell listens to whatever the party is willing to say — he does not push — and then does something he almost never does: he closes the ledger in front of him.

"I will tell you three true things, and then I will tell you an address, and then we will agree this conversation was about overdue books. First: what you are describing is not in any collection I keep, and I keep the collections that officially do not exist. Second: the Church's Office of Omens would receive you politely, question you separately, and resolve you into a file. I recommend against becoming a file. Third: there is a woman in the Coppergate district who was doing what the Office of Omens pretends to do before your instructors were born. She sees people who are referred, and she has not accepted a referral from me in eleven years. Tell her the archivist still keeps her letters. The house with the blue shutters, above the copyist's shop, Ninth Lane off the Coppergate fountain. Go in daylight. She distrusts people who prefer the dark — and lately, my young colleagues, so do I."

(DM note: Vell knew Vaelindra when both were young functionaries — he in the imperial archives, she in the Church — and he is one of perhaps three people who know why her Church career actually ended. He will not say so. His referral phrase, "the archivist still keeps her letters," is genuine: he does, and she will know instantly that he means it. Eleven years ago he sent her someone whose vision ended badly; he has been ashamed to presume on her since. He is a superb

recurring resource — research, restricted stacks, institutional memory — and his protectiveness of Vaelindra is real and mutual.)

SCENE 5: THE STILL WATERS

Coppergate is a middle district: copyists, instrument-makers, retired functionaries, laundry between balconies. The blue-shuttered house is exactly where Vell said. A copyist's shop occupies the ground floor; a side stair leads up. The woman who answers the door is small, silver-haired, and entirely unremarkable except for the quality of her attention, which arrives like a hand on the shoulder.

Run the scene by her rules, which she states pleasantly and does not bend: she asks the questions first. Before she will hear one word of the vision, she seats the party, makes tea with unhurried thoroughness, and interviews them — names later, first: Who sent you? (The letters phrase visibly lands; something in her posture sets down a weight.) When did it happen — the hour, as precisely as you can? Had you shed blood that day? (She asks it evenly. The Redwatch answer interests her greatly.) Has anything cold come into your possession? (If the party carries Dren's medallion and produces it, she goes still for three full seconds — the only crack in her composure all evening — then asks, quietly, to be allowed to not touch it.)

Only then does she hear the vision — and she takes it like a physician taking a history: no gasps, no mysticism, a pen moving in a ledger of her own shorthand, one clarifying question per detail. Which direction did the flames lean? Did the sound arrive before or after your gaze was pulled upward? How many towers did you count? When the account is complete, she sets down the pen, and the session ends on the following, delivered with the calm of a woman who has waited a long time to be wrong and has just learned she is not:

"I am going to tell you three things tonight, and none of them is a comfort, and the rest will wait for daylight, because you are exhausted and this next part deserves your whole mind. The first thing: your vision is real. It is not stress, not shared fancy, not something you ate. I have taken accounts like a physician takes histories for fifty years, and yours has the pulse of the true ones. The second thing: it is not yours alone. I have heard these images before — not this vision, but its relatives. Fragments. Edges. The storm, the wrong-colored fire, the thing behind the sky. They have been arriving for a long time, from people who had never met, and lately they arrive more often. Whatever this is, it did not begin with you, and it is already in motion. The third thing — and hold to this one, because it is the only mercy I have for you tonight: in fifty years, I have never known a shared vision to show what must happen. They show what is coming if nothing changes. Nothing changes, that is, unless someone changes it. Go and sleep, if you can. Come back at the tenth bell. And children —" she glances, once, at the pocket where the cold thing rides, " — walk in the light on your way home."

End the session there. Do not play the walk home. Session Three opens at the tenth bell, with tea going cold and

Vaelindra deciding — based on everything the party said and did tonight — how much of the truth they can carry.

STAT BLOCKS

Provincial Soldier

Medium humanoid (any race), lawful neutral

Armor Class: 16 (chain shirt, shield)

Hit Points: 11 (2d8 + 2)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
13 (+1)	12 (+1)	12 (+1)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)	10 (+0)

Skills: Perception +2

Senses: passive Perception 12

Languages: Common

Challenge: 1/8 (25 XP)

Unpaid and Unenthusiastic. The soldier has disadvantage on saving throws against being frightened while Sergeant Malich is incapacitated, and will accept any face-saving surrender offered.

ACTIONS

Spear. Melee or Ranged Weapon Attack: +3 to hit, reach 5 ft. or range 20/60 ft., one target. Hit: 4 (1d6 + 1) piercing damage, or 5 (1d8 + 1) piercing damage if used with two hands to make a melee attack.

Sergeant Petra Malich

Medium humanoid (human), lawful neutral

Armor Class: 17 (splint)

Hit Points: 32 (5d8 + 10)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
15 (+2)	11 (+0)	14 (+2)	11 (+0)	13 (+1)	12 (+1)

Skills: Athletics +4, Insight +3, Perception +3

Senses: passive Perception 13

Languages: Common

Challenge: 1 (200 XP)

Not Dying for Scrip. If reduced below half her hit points, or if three of her soldiers fall, Malich orders a withdrawal and yields the crossing. She fights to protect her men, not the toll.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Malich makes two longsword attacks.

Longsword. Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 6 (1d8 + 2) slashing damage, or 7 (1d10 + 2) slashing damage if used with two hands.

Bridge Enforcer

Medium humanoid (any race), neutral

Armor Class: 11 (leather armor)

Hit Points: 32 (5d8 + 10)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
15 (+2)	11 (+0)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)

Skills: Intimidation +2

Senses: passive Perception 10

Languages: Common

Challenge: 1 (200 XP)

Pack Tactics. The enforcer has advantage on attack rolls against a creature if at least one of the enforcer's allies is within 5 feet of the creature and the ally isn't incapacitated.

Paid, Not Owned. The enforcer abandons Odric Hale if reduced below half hit points or if half the enforcers have fallen.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The enforcer makes two mace attacks.

Mace. Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 5 (1d6 + 2) bludgeoning damage.

Odric Hale

Medium humanoid (human), neutral evil

Armor Class: 14 (fine studded leather)

Hit Points: 22 (4d8 + 4)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	14 (+2)	12 (+1)	14 (+2)	11 (+0)	15 (+2)

Skills: Deception +6, Insight +2, Persuasion +4

Senses: passive Perception 10

Languages: Common, plus two regional dialects

Challenge: 1/2 (100 XP)

A Businessman, Not a Soldier. Odric surrenders immediately when personally endangered or when his writ is credibly exposed before witnesses. He fights only if cornered with no offer on the table.

ACTIONS

Rapier. Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 6 (1d8 + 2) piercing damage.

Honeyed Misdirection (Recharge 5–6). Odric targets one creature within 30 feet that can hear him. The target must succeed on a DC 12 Wisdom saving throw or have disadvantage on its next attack roll or ability check before the end of its next turn, as Odric's patter momentarily convinces it of some procedural irregularity.

NPC QUICK REFERENCE

Sgt. Petra Malich: Competent, underpaid, privately ashamed of the toll. Speech: clipped, formal, thaws only if respected. Thread: a good soldier serving a bad arrangement — exactly the person a restored empire would need, and exactly the person it is currently losing.

Semya of Halvenne: Old, unhurried, unfrightened — she has already lost the things fear protects. Speech: proverbs and weather. Thread: her people's resettlement (Dravenna, if the party thinks of it) becomes a small living consequence of the party's choices.

Odric Hale: Charming parasite with perfect paperwork. Speech: bureaucratic honorifics deployed like weapons. Thread: if escorted to justice, his dead-seal supplier is a loose end pointing into Rivergate, the capital's under-regulated river quarter and the natural home of its document underworld — useful later (see the sourcebook's Plot Hooks: The Seal Dealer of Rivergate).

Archivist Dathenor Vell: Ancient, dry, precise; volunteers nothing, forgets nothing. Speech: numbered lists, then silence. Thread: the party's door into restricted institutional memory — and one of three living people who know why Vaelindra's Church career truly ended.

Vaelindra of the Still Waters: Full profile in the campaign sourcebook. This session uses only the surface of her: the method, the tea, the ledger, the three things. Everything she is holding back — Nyreeza, the founding, her decision about the party — is Session Three's material and beyond.

OPTIONAL CONTENT (BEYOND THE FIVE-HOUR CORE)

The Wandering Lecturer (~40 minutes): At a waypoint inn, one Professor Emeritus Pontellus Vorn — expelled from three provincial academies, by his own proud account “for excessive rigor” — delivers an unsolicited evening lecture on the capital's three walls, wrong in nearly every particular and magnificent in all of them. Let an academy-trained party squirm, correct him, or bait him. Comic texture with one buried gift: among his nonsense, one claim is true — “the Long Wall was built for a city that never came” — and a party that fact-checks him later discovers the strange experience of the fool being right once. Vorn is a renewable comic NPC; he will resurface in Aenodira, lecturing pigeons if no one else will listen.

DIVERGING PATHS (DM ONLY)

Outcomes here echo forward. Record them in the Branch Ledger.

Semya's people: Resettled in Dravenna: forty grateful witnesses and a standing Ostmark listening post; the Forty Witnesses hook fires warm. Worth more than it looks under the new Laws: Book Two makes a witnessed oath the thing that binds at law, and most of the empire cannot read — so forty people willing to stand up and say what they saw is a legal instrument, not just goodwill. Left to the road: they land in Farrowgate, and the Session Five optional client — the family whose daughter went to Greywell — lands among them, harder and angrier. Both branches work; they change the temperature of every later Farrowgate scene.

Sergeant Malich: Respected: a quiet friend inside a border lord's garrison — and if Lord Ostrev's toll ever reaches an imperial court, a conscience deciding which way to testify. Humiliated before her men or forced to yield the crossing: Ostrev hears of it, and the party has a minor lord's durable enmity plus a checkpoint that remembers them on every future eastern journey.

Odric Hale: Escorted to capital authorities: his dead-seal supplier becomes discoverable evidence — Session Five's Rivergate investigation begins with a live lead and Tirell Mosse already nervous. Released with his “apology”: he resurfaces working a different bridge under a different dead office, and Mosse's shop has had time to tidy its ledgers. Killed: the supplier thread survives, but colder.

The report and the vision: If the party volunteers the shared vision in their official exercise report, it enters academy records — and the Office of Omens' Session Five attention arrives with documentary teeth instead of rumor. Discretion here is armor later; indiscretion is not fatal, merely expensive.

LOOT AND FOUND REWARDS — SESSION TWO — THE ROAD BACK

Find	Value / Effect
Odric's strongbox	45 gp, a forged-seal kit (evidence; worth 25 gp to exactly the wrong people), and toll receipts naming payers — paper leverage in the Ostrev matter
The dead Roads Commission seal	Story item — the thread to Mosse (Session Five)
Semya's gratitude	A blessing in the old country way. Not an item. Worth more than most items

REWARDS AND ADVANCEMENT

Coin: modest — Odric's 20 gp "apology" and up to 35 gp recovered from his strongbox if the bridge ends in force; this session pays in relationships, not gold. Reputation: Malich, Semya's forty witnesses, Vell, and Vaelindra are all ledger entries whose value compounds. XP for tables using it: roughly 500–800 depending on encounters run and how they resolved (award full encounter value for nonviolent resolutions — they are the harder path). Advancement: the party reaches 4th level at the start of Session Three, after the tenth-bell conversation with Vaelindra concludes.

~

"Walk in the light on your way home."